

Soft Rush

Juncus effusus

Common Rush



QUALITIES

A clumping wetland rush forming distinct fountain-like tussocks 2 to 3 feet tall. Smooth cylindrical bright-green stems rise vertically from a tight basal clump — the stems are the photosynthetic organs (true leaves are reduced to small basal sheaths). Inconspicuous brown panicles of tiny flowers burst out from the side of the stems near the top in early summer, persisting as structural seedheads through fall.

CARE

Wet to consistently moist soil; tolerates seasonal flooding. Full sun to part shade. Hardy to USDA Zone 3. Plant from plug stock or 1-gallon container, 12 to 18 inches apart for a clump-forming display. Long-lived; established clumps can persist for decades. No maintenance needed; can be cut to 6 inches in late winter, though leaving stems standing through winter provides cover for small wildlife.

HISTORY

Soft Rush is one of the few truly cosmopolitan plants — it grows wild on every continent except Antarctica. Throughout its range it has been used for centuries to weave chair seats, mats, and baskets. In medieval England, the pith of the stems was soaked in tallow to make "rushlights," the cheapest form of household lighting before commercial candles became affordable. The Anishinaabe and other Great Lakes peoples used it similarly for mat-making.

REASON TO BE

Soft Rush is a structural element of vegetated bioswales and rain gardens, providing vertical contrast to the horizontal arch of sedges and the showy spikes of Iris and Cardinal Flower. The dense clumps shelter amphibians, small birds, and overwintering native bees. It tolerates the seasonal flooding that defeats most other plants — making it a reliable choice for the low spots of a vegetated swale where standing water occasionally sits.